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Department : EXTC

Company: PhonePe
Job Profile: SDE
Offer Type: Internship + Placement
Internship Stipend: 80K
CTC: 33.5L (19.25L base + 5L joining bonus + 8.5L stocks)
Location: Bangalore
Process Date: - PPT + OA : 7th July, 2025

- Interview : 8th July, 2025

Placement Process:

1. **Online Assessment** [All the students who had Applied appeared for it Nearly 200+]

We were Asked to report at 1 : 40 PM for PPT (Pre Placement Talk) followed by OA.OA was initially scheduled at 3 : 30 PM however it started nearly at 4 : 00 PM.

Total 4 Questions were there in this Round and duration was 90 Minutes (1 and Half Hour)

Question 1 :

Reference Question : [Connected Components in an Undirected Graph](#)

It was mostly Like this same question we have to figure out the Number of Connected Components and we were asked to finally print the final cost where cost was 1 for connecting 2 different components.

I instantly came up with approach of DSU and coded it in nearly 8 to 10 Minutes as DSU is my favourite Data Structure. I got all the Test cases Passed and got AC on it.

However, few people also solved it by using BFS / DFS. But One common mistake which I noticed was alot of people even after realizing that it was a DSU question were not able to code DSU. So, I would suggest stop using Templates at least one month before Placement. It was an easy one If you have command on DSU. I would strongly recommend to learn DSU as it is favourite Topic of every PBC.

Question 2 :

Reference Question : [Array Description](#)

It was Almost same as this question from CSES. A slight change was there that At max Difference can be till k instead of 1 where k was an Integer Provided in the Input. I had solved this problem alot of times before still was not confident to code it that fast so decided to go for 3rd one and then came to it and coded it. I was able to solve all the test cases apart from 5 test cases which I was not able to figure out initially but later on realized that I was not doing Modulo $1e9 + 7$ and the moment I did that all the test cases got Passed.

Question 3 :

You were provided with an Array of length n and a variable s and a Variable k . Your task was to print the number of pairs where sum of two elements was equal to s and sum of bit positions of 1 of those numbers should be less than or equal to k .

Ex.: $n = 5$ arr = [1 2 7 3 5] This is the Array and say $s = 10$ and $k = 5$

So, Answer will be 1 in this case as 3,7 is the Only Pair satisfying the conditions. Here $3 + 7 = 10$ and In binary $3 = 011$ and $7 = 111$. For 3 There is a 1 at 0th position and another one at 1st position so sum of bit positions = 1 and for 7 there is 1 at 0th,1st and 2nd Position so sum of bit positions = 3. So, total sum of bit Positions = $1 + 3 = 4$ which is less than k in this case.

The trick in this question was the constraint as n was at max equal to 1000 so $O(n*n)$ can be easily passed. So, without even a single thought I applied Brute Force I got all the Test Cases Pass. One thing I noticed was though I read the question completely but while Implementing I forgot to check the bit positions condition and just checked the condition of pairs sum equal to s but still I got and all the test cases got passed. But after realising that later on I again came back to it even after getting AC I improved the code as we were Informed that code will be seen and on the basis of that shortlisting will be done. This was an easy Problem mostly was there for speed solving.

Question 4 :

Reference Question : [M-Coloring Problem](#)

It was mostly like this same Problem with Proper story Plot but the Main trick in this Problem was to take the Input as they didn't mentioned that what number of edges were to be taken as an Input. I didn't met a Single Person who had solved it completely. I was nearly having more than half an hour. I tried Applying all the different techniques which I knew mainly I tried using getline as I code in C++ but that didn't worked. One thing which alot people did was they directly Printed possible as answer can either be Possible or Impossible. On printing Possible nearly 7 of 11 test cases were getting Passed. I knew this trick but didn't used it as it was Mentioned in PPT that code will be reviewed by Phone Pe Team. I also knew that last year with 2 complete and half Partial submissions candidates have received call.. So, I was almost sure that I will be getting the OA shortlisting.

30 Candidates were Shortlisted after OA Round. List came nearly around 10 : 00 PM and we were asked to report at 8 : 00 AM the next day.

2. **Technical Round 1** [All 30 shortlisted Candidates gave this Round]

There were 3 Panels. I was in 2nd Panel. So, have to wait for 1 hour from 9 to 10. Then some of my friend from panel 1 after first Round told me that they were asked questions on Binary Search and Binary Lifting. I was quite confident afterwards as these are My most strong topics in CP. Then Finally I went for Round 1.

Interviewer Didn't at all looked at my resume and not even asked for My Introduction. He tried to make me comfortable and then directly started with the Problem. He was very helpful in entire Round.

Question 1 :

I had never seen exact same question Previously.

Problem Statement : You are given a Binary Tree and for each level you have to find minimum number of swaps to sort nodes of that Particular level and at the end you have to return the total Number of swaps required for all the levels of tree.

I started with explaining that how we'll take all the nodes of each level using queue and store it in vector. So, question boils down to finding minimum number of swaps required for sorting the elements of a vector and likewise we can do for all the Levels. Now, thing was How can we solve it for a particular vector. I directly gave him the Merge Sort approach which seemed appropriate to me at that time. However he didn't looked satisfied with merge sort. So, I decided to go for another approach through I was not having any other approach but with nearly 3 minutes of strong thinking I came up with Approach of DSU (As I mentioned earlier it is my most favourite data structure so I almost try it in every question)

I explained him that we can find Number of cycles using DSU and total number of swaps will be equal to size of a Particular component - 1 and likewise we can add it for all the components. But then He asked me how will I code DSU as Numbers can be 1000,200 or any big number then I told him about Coordinate Compression and with that it becomes a standard DSU Problem. He just looked too satisfied with approach. Then He asked me to code it. He asked me to write complete code along with syntax with Proper Assumptions on Paper. I was completely Comfortable in it and coded it Properly.

Question 2 :

Reference Question : [Maximum Sum Combination](#)

It was exactly this same Problem but the change here was that there can be n arrays not necessarily 2 Arrays. I had solved the above mentioned Problem. So, directly came up with Priority Queue but was not able to figure out for n arrays. I tried alot of Approaches but was not able to come up with a complete correct solution. At once even Interviewer stopped looking at me and was doing his own work. But I was still explaining him My approach without stopping which I have learned from Striver's [Media.net](#) Experience that you should never sit Blank in Interview even if you know that your Approach is complete wrong. As in real life Industry work not necessarily you will be having solution of every Problem but one thing which should be there in you to continuously try for finding the solution.

3. **Hiring Manager Round** [Around 16 students]

After hearing everyone's experience I was not quite confident that whether I will be getting call or not. But all of sudden I received a call from my TPC and all of sudden I ran for taking my resume from My Bag and went for HM Round. He was Managing Head at PhonePe and was just too good and helpful. This round was highly focused on my Resume.

Even He didn't looked at hard copy of my resume and instead he was having my resume open on his Laptop. Even he didn't asked me the Standard Introduce Yourself Question and rather directly started with my Projects and asked about my One project on which I was confident enough. I explained him my Test My Case Project which is a Chrome Extension I made for Codeforces for validating Test Cases. He looked interested to know how it exactly worked I explained him it's complete working and then he asked why I made this to which I replied I made it for myself as I was facing that issue on Codeforces which I think made a Good Impression on him. Then he grinded me on my resume with questions like My leadership qualities, My role as Executive in IETE and a lot of such questions. Then he asked me

My most frequent used App to which I replied Youtube as I knew he will be asking me the System Design / Architecture of Youtube. I had read a lot of Past Year Experience of PhonePe due to which I knew this is sure shot question for PhonePe HM round. Later on he asked me to tell how Youtube Recommendation system works to which I took him to complete Core CS, ML and DSA which is My strong zone. (I wanted to show that I had good command on Core CS) Then He asked me a lot of Behavioral questions on which I was almost prepared. He also asked me my weakness to which I replied that I over optimize things as I come from CP background and then told him that I am continuously trying to Improve it.

Then at the end, He asked me Tell me a Reason why we should not hire you to which I replied that I don't think so I have any such qualities and I do possess all the main qualities required for SDE 1 at PhonePe and even If I don't have I will learn them faster. He then asked me to ask any questions I had then I asked him few questions which I prepared during the PPT (Pre Placement Talk) which made him feel that I was highly focused during PPT. He looked Impressed and I almost knew that I am getting the call for final Round.

4. **Technical Round 2** [Around 11 students]

I received the Message that I have been shortlisted for 3rd and Final Round of the Day which is Technical Round 2. At the very beginning of this I was told that I have been strongly recommended by Manager Sir. The Interviewer was very helpful and talked with me for a while to make me comfortable. Then He started with DSA questions

Question 1 :

Reference Question : [Drunken Maze](#)

Don't worry It was not the same Problem but it was very easy as compared to the above Problem with just Direction condition. As I had solved this Problem just recently I directly told him the Approach to which he was satisfied and directly told me to do the code. I asked him what is the Expectations with Quality of code to which he replied he has to show My code to the Team. So, I maintained High Quality of Code which I had practiced a lot for Interviews. He looked satisfied with the code and then fast forward he asked me the follow ups to which I replied very faster. (Graphs have always been my strongest Part in my Complete Coding Journey thanks to Striver for that)

Question 2 :

Reference Question : [Painting the Walls](#)

Interviewer directly Showed me on Leetcode Itself and asked me for the Approach after looking directly at constraints I directly replied with DP without a Second thought to which he agreed. I gave him 4 different recursive functions on the spot all of which were correct. But he wanted me to tell the approach using only those dp states which he want. I was not able to figure out exactly the states he wanted but eventually with certain talk with him I gave him the approach he wanted. I asked him that should I go for code to which he said Time's Up. But then He said that don't worry You are good guy for PhonePe to which I replied "Ok, So let's meet in the Office" This was something I had never thought I will say to my Interviewer. He replied with yess for sure. With that I came out from Interview Room.

I was the first one to Complete all the 3 Rounds and So, I knew that I have to wait for nearly 2 hours and eventually all of us ended up waiting for nearly 3 to 3 and half hours and finally Shortlisting Came. 7 of Us were hired with (Internship + FTE offer). Later on I got to know that I was the first one ever from EXTC department to get into Phone Pe. To someone like who always wanted a PBC to work on it felt like dream come true and that everyday grinding just seemed worth it.

Useful Tips:

I will highly Recommend doing CP as alot of Codeforces and Algorithmic Questions were there. If you are someone who has not done CP than as of now Try to do CP 31 sheet from TLE Eliminators atleast till 1500 Rating starting from 1100 that will boost your confidence.

Have Practice of explaining solutions that is more Important than actually Solving the Problem. I used to Practice it at home that how I will show Interviewer about my Intution and how I exactly came up with this Particular Approach.

Try to do time bound Practice for OA. You can try Virtual Contests on Codeforces and Leetcode. They are very nice for Practice. If you have CF fear then also it's fine You can practice Leetcode. Leetcode is more than enough.

Make sure to revise standard DSA questions (Striver's SDE sheet Highly Recommended). As there are some questions for which a Particular Optimization is not possible until you have studied it from Somewhere. Also do make sure to star mark the ones which you felt alot tougher and do make the notes that what particular point about that Problem made you star mark that Problem it will help alot at the end moment I just revised my marked notes on striver tuf website in metro (20 minutes) that's it.

Try to learn some Advanced concept as well as Topics which were never asked are getting asked nowadays. Some Important ones which I feel you should do Binary Lifting (was asked this year to Panel 1), Tries (was asked in 2 different rounds to many People), DP (digit DP and DP with Bitmasking Watch kartik arora YT videos for both)

Also, have some good projects on Resume on which you are strong enough to talk on even for hours If someone wants you to. Try to solve some real world problem. Problem doesn't need to be too big even If a small issue is there and you have figured it you that will make a lot of sense than someone who is having complete GIT cloned project.

Specifically for PhonePe make sure to learn System Design of Any app as this is for sure guaranteed question in HR Round. If you don't have time then let me tell you Youtube had the easiest architecture of all the Apps out there (That one Neetcode video is more than enough if you have done Basics of System Design)

At the End Remember It is not the last opportunity You will be having a lot of better options further as well. Just make sure to give your 100% Best so that you don't have Anything to Regret.

Resources (Which I followed) :

1. DSA :

During My Time (2022) Codehelp DSA series was the most popular one but

Nowadays, many of people also follow striver that's completely your choice.

[Codehelp DSA Playlist](#) (All the Topics Except for Graph, DP)

Striver For [Graph](#) and [DP](#)

I personally have followed alot of Playlists for Dp for CP mainly : [Priyansh Aggrawal](#) [Vivek Gupta](#)

[Binary Search](#) , [Two Pointers](#) and [DSU](#) : Codeforces EDU Section (Atleast 2 Practice sets)

2. Web Development :

[HTML](#) [CSS](#) [JavaScript](#) : Apna College

React : [Traversy Media](#) [Codevolution](#)

[NodeJs](#) [ExpressJS](#) : Any One Shot Video which You can understand

First learn this fast to get the basics clear

Then Pick Some Random Projects from [JS mastery](#) and try to follow end to end and then go for your own Project and make sure you include Github link and Demo video link from Yt that makes really good Impression.

3. Core CS :

For Core CS just have a look at GFG top 100 Questions for each of these subjects

[OOPS](#) : Rohit Negi

[DBMS](#) : Code Help

[Operating System](#) : Gate Smashers

[Computer Networks](#) : Gate Smashers

4. System Design :

[High Level Design](#) : Concept and Coding

[Low Level Design](#) : Coder Army (Not Important for PhonePe)

For any further help feel free to Reach out to me - [LinkedIn](#)